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Sufism as World Literature

9 May 2025

Once in an Imaginary World, Rabi'a and Rumi Met

There lived Rabi'a, a kindred spirit and a young soul,

She lived in Arabia, where everything built with *meverit*.

She dreamed of places, *madrasas*, and people,

And her only dream was to find Allah.

She had always heard about Him,

From her family, friends, and a *mullah*.

But never really understood,

What it means to “find from every place—Allah?”

She ventured out into the big *dunya* and *sahra*,

And was very confused about,

Where to find and how to find Him.

On her way, Rabi'a met a man,

Who was the Sufi and wise one of his time.

Rabi'a was astonished by his wisdom,

And this person of spiritual knowledge was Rumi.

“I want to seek forgiveness and love from Allah,

And what are the ways to enter *Jannah*?”

Rabi'a, a young inexperienced asked questions swiftly,

And Rumi, a patient poet scholar listened to her attentively.

Then Rumi took his reed flute,

Of whose song took over all *sahra* and *dunya*.

And Rabi'a felt a tension, a purifying one,

Only then she realized everything was behind the veil.

Rumi said: “Only with true love, you can find Allah,

From every corner, tree, and a *mahallah*.

Only when your love toward Him transcends,

Then you will understand what it means to find Allah.

Break free from worldly love,

Right now and as long as you're alive.

Love Him with your every breath and *wujud*,

And it should extend beyond your rational self.”

Rabi’a understood that her *varlık* was intended for Him,

And she prayed, prayed, and fell deeply in love with Him.

She got *ilham*, a desire, and divine love,

And she, too, became a *kamil insan* of her time.

Every deadline I chase, each goal I claim as mine,

I pause and wonder: Is there more to this climb?

Time runs fast at Dartmouth, so I run still faster,

But if the mind’s a servant, who, then, is the master?

April 27th 2025

Author’s note: Writing this poem was a very interesting journey, a quite different assignment compared to my other classes. I was first very stuck about where to begin, what to convey and how in this poem; however, I had an intention to revitalize Rabi’a and Rumi together in one time

and place. I dreamed of them having a conversation together. The poem is set around the 13th century when Rumi lived, and in Arabia (it's not a single country, but in my poem it is). I also wanted to use Arabic words in an English poem, drawing inspiration from "Listen!" I felt that If I were to translate, some English words would still fail to deliver what I actually wanted to say. It was challenging because I write in my Karakalpak language differently, with a different grammar and rhyme style. Drawing some inspiration from Rumi, I approached this poem in a couplet style.

It had been a long time since I last wrote any poem, but I used to in the past. Especially in middle school, I used to compose a lot of creative writing and even published my poems in several journals. Time passed, and I had less desire to write. While writing this poem, I often felt that the overall message was becoming too childish with a complicated question, "Where to find Allah?" Wouldn't it be too broad and stupid if I wrote that? Especially for Rabi'a, a distinguished Sufist, approaching such a question would be inappropriate, I thought a lot. However, my main intention was to mean that too often children don't know the true beauty of their religion, and they often feel obliged to worship and follow that religion without knowing why. My intention was to begin with that question, and bring the reader to what Rumi believed to be to truly love Allah. I especially channeled some insights from "Rabi'a: From Narrative to Myth" and "Song of the Reed." I wanted to break any conventions and ideas about Rabi'a and Rumi that we gathered in class, while also keeping some of them.

What we had read and covered in our class about Rumi taught me about how Sufists loved God so dearly to the point they transcended beyond their bodies. The whirling dervishes would dance non-stop in a circle to show their devotion to God, and I also wanted to include how a reed flute was an influencing musical instrument in Sufism. Rumi and Rabia's role in my poem is like that

of a *mu'allim* and student role, where Rumi is educating Rabi'a. The poem on a larger scale includes my realities of the world, where religion still plays a role in my decisions and actions. I question my belief in God and practicing Islam in general a lot, but I also appreciate it because of its influence on me as a person and on my morals. Here are the translations of the foreign words used in the poem: *merverit* - pearl, *madrasa* - educational institution, *mullah* - Muslim leader/mosque clergy, *dunya* - world, *sahra* - desert, *Jannah* - heaven/paradise, *mahallah* - neighborhood, *wujud* - existence/spiritual being, *varlık* - existence/body, *ilham* - inspiration, *kamil insan* - perfect human.